

GOOD READS

This year's top 10 books tackle censorship, crime and compassion



LIFE+TRAVEL
Ireland's rock star
A creative sojourn to the Burren's vast landscape on country's rugged west coast.

REAL ESTATE
Naming your home
Americans giving the longtime European practice a modern, fanciful twist.

WINNER OF 28 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Final

Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, DECEMBER 7, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

U.S. SENATE RACE

Downstate voters key to victory for Dems

In primary, credibility beyond Chicago and its suburbs is essential

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

An endorsement by a former one-term lieutenant governor who has been out of office for a decade ordinarily wouldn't hold much significance in a primary campaign for U.S. Senate.

But an endorsement from Sheila Simon might be a slight exception. Not because of the ex-lieutenant governor's individual political influence, but because, even as the Democratic voter base in downstate Illinois is ever-shrinking, her support highlights that statewide candidates must still spend considerable time and energy wooing party members far from deep-blue Cook County.

That's become particularly true in the Democratic Party's Senate primary campaign. All three major candidates in the race are from the Chicago region and are running to succeed retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin of Springfield, who for the last 28 years has balanced an upstate-downstate split in Illinois' Senate representation.

Although ballots cast outside the six-county Chicago region accounted for less than a quarter of the overall vote in the past two contested Democratic Senate primaries, in 2010 and 2016, the announcement last week that Simon was backing U.S. Rep. Raja Krishnamoorthi's candidacy serves as a reminder that all three top-tier candidates in the March 17 primary know building credibility beyond Chicago and its increasingly Democratic suburbs is essential.

Simon's backing does, of course, carry some modest political weight. Now a law professor at Southern Illinois University in Carbondale, she's the daughter of the late U.S. Sen. Paul Simon, the man Durbin replaced in the Senate in 1997. She also remains a recognizable and well-connected figure in a region where her family name is tied to the identity and history

Turn to Campaign, Page 8

OPERATION MIDWAY BLITZ



'Really reckless'

Experts: From shooting to Slim Jims, immigration agents' poor tactics made for needless safety risks

By Joe Mahr and Gregory Royal Pratt
Chicago Tribune

Operation Midway Blitz flooded Chicago with federal immigration agents, fueled frequent protests and — to policing experts — offered something else.

The operation showed how not to police.

In incident after incident, experts said, immigration and

Border Patrol agents routinely took actions that not only infuriated civil libertarians and everyday residents but broke urban policing protocols meant to limit danger for suspects, protesters, passersby and even officers themselves.

"They haven't done anything that is anywhere close to a standard police practice," said former Customs and Border Protection Commissioner Gil Kerlikowske, a former Seattle police chief and

an Obama-era appointee.

Added former Chicago police Superintendent Eddie Johnson: "In my humble opinion, it's a breeding ground for disaster, the way they apply their tactics and methods. ... From what I see, they just seem to be just really reckless."

A Tribune review of the feds' policing tactics follows a scathing, 233-page opinion by U.S. District Judge Sara Ellis that called out many of the federal

agents' tactics from a constitutional perspective. And the subsequent release of footage from agents' body cameras late last month not only contradicted claims they made in use-of-force reports but chronicled some of the chaos on the streets.

While some of that chaos for sure could be blamed on the actions of some protesters and arrest targets, career urban policing leaders blamed much of that chaos — in both incidents cited by Ellis and others — on what the leaders described as shoddy policing tactics shunned by more

Turn to Tactics, Page 4

Above: A federal agent points his gun sideways during an immigration enforcement action in the Little Village neighborhood on Nov. 8. Longtime urban police leaders questioned that tactic and many others used by immigration agents during Operation Midway Blitz. The policing leaders said the agents routinely behaved in ways that — beyond potentially being unconstitutional — unnecessarily endangered suspects, protesters, innocent bystanders and the agents themselves. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

INSIDE: Kristi Noem's appearance on Saturday at the annual Christmas tree ship ceremony sparks protests at Navy Pier. In Elgin, federal immigration agents use tear gas and pepper spray on a crowd gathered to protest an arrest. Stories in Chicagoland, Page 3

White Eagle closes after decades as Polish community hub



The White Eagle banquet hall in Niles is permanently closed. Gabi Vargas, a sales representative who started working there as a teen, reminisces there on Nov. 24. TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Niles banquet hall played host to litany of dignitaries, celebrities

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

The phone at the White Eagle in Niles keeps ringing, with longtime customers asking for one last pierogi or a final bowl of its famed mushroom barley soup.

An older woman cried when she learned it wouldn't be possible, recalled office manager Diane Palazzo of Victoria Venues, the current owner. The banquet hall had quietly closed its doors several weeks ago.

"She was totally shocked," said Palazzo, who has attended events at White Eagle since childhood. "She said, 'I don't think you know what it means. I've had everything there.' This is where all of her memories were."

Turn to Hall, Page 2

INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Bears cornerback a difference-maker

Nahshon Wright's "emotional" breakout season for the Bears comes as he mourns his JUCO coach John Beam. Plus, Al Harris has made an impact on the Bears for years. And wherever he goes, takeaways follow. Chicago Sports

JUSTICE DEPARTMENT PLAYS UP ARREST IN BOMB CASE: Yet leaders who announced the arrest were silent about the violence that took place on Jan. 6, 2021, at the U.S. Capitol. Nation & World

